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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 4 Wamutira: The First Wife

As small girls, we never wore very much—only a piece of blanket on the upper body and sometimes another piece for the skirt. But grown women like my mother wore a dress made out of three pieces of antelope skin, called a *njuri*. One piece was used as the front part, and the other two pieces went behind. When sitting down, my mother would wrap each of those pieces around her thighs and then tuck in the front piece.

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What was I like as a child? I can't remember well, but I was told that I used to just stay at one place and mother would bring my food there. Maybe I was quiet.

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We played games after we returned home from working in the *shamba*, like wrestling with each other and a game where we used to collect smooth stones from the river and gather in a group on the ground. Then one of us would throw the stones up in the air and try and catch all of them on the back of the hands. The game is called *ciũthi*.

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Because there were many children in our compound, sometimes we would fight. But then any grown person nearby would come and threaten us with a beating if he or she ever saw us fighting again. That usually stopped us. It was only our mothers who were involved though, or some older son of my father. My father, being a chief, was never at home to know what happened to us children. He was always away on some business.

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Mariika were important because, as one was growing up, she learned how to treat people in different age groups. People of different *mariika* would not abuse each other or even greet each other. But you, if you were of my same age group, when we met we would greet one another and laugh and tell jokes or do anything we wanted together. We would never talk with those of other age groups, especially those younger than us.

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My mother used to tell me never to appear near a place where older people were gathered talking. We never stayed in the same house with my father, and when he came to visit my mother we children were told to leave so that we would not hear what their talk was about. When we got to be a little older, we went to our oldest mother, the one called Nini, and she taught us things—like not to play with boys as their games are never good and would end up in bad things, such that they would lie on top of us. Nini told us how we should behave at dances once we were circumcised. And sometimes she would tell us stories at night around the cooking fire. There is one I remember well:

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Long, long ago, during the time of Ndemi and Mathathi, there was one man who used to go to the forest to make knives, spears, and shields. He was a blacksmith. When he went there one day, he left his wife pregnant at home, and as the time reached for her to deliver she was assisted by an ogre.

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